



» AFC ASIAN CUP

Stern challenge: India has recently shown that it can go toe-to-toe against the better Asian sides but the AFC Asian Cup promises to be a different ball game. AIFF MEDIA

EXPECTATIONS TEMPERED BUT INDIA CAN TAKE FLIGHT IN QATAR

The Blue Tigers will **open their Asian Cup campaign** against the 2015 Asian champion, the Socceroos, one of the favourites to lift the title.

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Football has always embraced underdog stories warmly. Be it the rise of South Korea in 2002 or the recent fourth-place finish of Morocco in the FIFA World Cup, the element of surprise only adds magic to the beautiful game.

When India, the lowest-ranked team (102) in its group, takes the field in the AFC Asian Cup in Qatar, it will look to beat the odds under Croat Igor Stimac.

Though the team's quality, on paper, is well short of its group-stage opponents, Australia, Syria, and

Uzbekistan, all of whom are equally adept at making it to the knockouts, India's realistic target would be to avoid three defeats and, if at all, dare a win against the higher-ranked opponents.

The Blue Tigers will open their campaign against the 2015 Asian